

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Ethics

HUM 2 — Complete Study Reference

Course: **HUM 2**

Units: **3 units**

CHED Mandate: **GE Core Course**

Type: **Moral Philosophy**

CHAPTER 00

Course Overview

Ethics is a CHED-mandated General Education course examining how people determine what's right and wrong, and why. Unlike RIZAL (one person's story) or SOCSCI 3 (global systems), Ethics is about REASONING — you'll spend less time memorizing facts and more time learning to construct and evaluate moral arguments. Exams and papers in this course reward students who can APPLY a

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

framework to a new scenario, not just recite its definition.

How This Course Actually Gets Tested

Expect fewer "define this term" questions and more "here's a scenario — what would a Utilitarian say? What would Kant say?" questions. The frameworks in Chapters 03-06 aren't trivia to memorize in isolation — they're tools you're expected to actively APPLY to case studies, including ones you've never seen before.

Exam & Discussion Priority Map

Topic	Chapter	Weight	Format Usually Tested
Utilitarianism (Bentham, Mill)	03	Very High	Case application essay
Deontology / Kant's Categorical Imperative	04	Very High	Case application essay
Virtue Ethics (Aristotle)	05	High	Case application identification
Moral decision-	07	Medium-High	Structured case analysis

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Topic	Chapter	Weight	Format Usually Tested
-------	---------	--------	-----------------------------

making process			
Freedom, reason, will as moral conditions	02	Medium	Identification short essay
Natural Law & Justice/ Rights	06	Medium	Identification essay
Applied ethics (bioethics, tech, environment)	08	Medium	Position paper
Moral vs non-moral standards	01	Foundational	Identification

CHAPTER 01

What Is Ethics?

Before evaluating any moral question, you need precise vocabulary — the difference between ethics and morals, moral and non-moral standards, and whether right and wrong are universal or relative to culture. These distinctions get tested

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

directly and underpin every later chapter.

Ethics vs Morals — A Useful Working Distinction

Term	Definition
Morals	The actual beliefs, values, and codes of conduct a person or culture holds about right and wrong — lived, practiced standards.
Ethics	The philosophical STUDY of morals — systematic reflection on what makes actions right or wrong, and why. Ethics asks "why" morals are justified; it doesn't just describe them.

Moral vs Non-Moral Standards

Not every rule or standard is a MORAL one. This distinction is one of the most frequently tested concepts in the entire course.

Type	Definition	Example
Moral standards	Concern actions that	"Don't steal,"

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Type	Definition	Example
	seriously affect the wellbeing, rights, or dignity of others; involve genuine right/wrong; not created by authority — they're discovered/justified through reasoning	"Don't harm innocent people"
Non-moral standards	Rules of etiquette, law, grammar, fashion, or convention — matters of preference, custom, or arbitrary agreement, not fundamental right/wrong	"Don't wear white after a funeral," "Drive on the right side of the road"

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Exam-Critical Distinction
— Law vs Morality

Something can be LEGAL but IMMORAL (historically, slavery was legal in many places), and something can be ILLEGAL but arguably MORAL (civil disobedience against an unjust law, e.g. Rizal's own reformist writings were illegal under Spanish rule). Law and morality often overlap but are NOT the same thing — a frequently tested point.

Six Characteristics of
Moral Standards

Characteristic	What It Means
Involve serious wrongs or benefits	Moral standards concern things that can genuinely harm or help people, not trivial preferences
Overriding	Moral standards take priority over other standards (self-interest, law, custom) when they conflict

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Characteristic

What It Means

Not established
by authority

A law can be
repealed by a
legislature; a
genuine moral
truth can't
simply be
voted away

Universalizable

If an action is
right/wrong for
one person in
a situation, it's
right/wrong for
anyone in a
relevantly
similar
situation

Impartial

Moral
standards
consider
everyone's
interests fairly,
not just one
person's or
one group's

Associated with
special
emotions

Violating moral
standards
typically
triggers guilt,
shame, or
indignation —
unlike
breaking a
non-moral rule

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Cultural Relativism vs
Ethical Universalism

Position	Core Claim	Main Criticism
Cultural Relativism	What is morally right or wrong depends entirely on a given culture's beliefs — there is no single universal standard that applies across all societies	Makes it impossible to morally criticize ANY practice of another culture (even genuinely harmful ones), and can't explain moral progress within a culture over time
Ethical Universalism	Certain moral standards (e.g. against unjustified killing, torture) hold across all cultures, regardless of local	Risk of imposing one culture's values onto others under the guise of "universal" truth

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Position

Core
Claim

Main
Criticism

belief or
custom

A Common Essay Prompt
on This Chapter

"Is morality relative or universal?" Strong answers acknowledge BOTH real cultural variation in customs (funeral rites, greetings, dress) AND argue that some core moral standards (like prohibitions on unjustified killing) appear across virtually all human societies in some form — suggesting a middle ground rather than a purely relativist or purely universalist position.

CHAPTER 02

The Moral
Agent

A "moral agent" is someone capable of being held morally responsible for their actions. Not every being, and not every human act, qualifies. This chapter covers what makes an act genuinely moral — and what

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

conditions can remove or reduce responsibility.

Three Conditions for a Moral Act

Condition	Why It's Required
Freedom	An act must be done voluntarily. A person coerced, physically forced, or acting under genuine duress is NOT fully morally responsible for that act — freedom is the precondition for praise or blame.
Reason	The agent must understand what they are doing and its likely consequences. A person who genuinely cannot understand the nature of their act (e.g. due to severe cognitive impairment) has diminished moral responsibility.
Will (Intention)	The agent must intend the act, or at minimum, act knowingly. Accidents where genuinely no

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Condition

Why It's Required

reasonable
foresight was
possible are
treated differently
from deliberate
acts.

Exam-Critical Application

These three conditions explain WHY the law (and everyday moral judgment) treats a person who kills in self-defense differently from a premeditated murderer, and why we don't hold young children or people with severe mental incapacity to the same moral standard as competent adults — one or more of freedom, reason, or will is compromised or absent.

Feelings vs Reason in Moral Judgment

A recurring philosophical debate: should moral decisions be guided primarily by RATIONAL analysis, or does genuine moral judgment require EMOTIONAL response (empathy, compassion, moral intuition) as well?

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Position

Core Claim

Reason-centered view

Emotions are unreliable and biased; genuine moral reasoning must follow logical principles consistently, independent of how we happen to feel in the moment (this view underlies Kant's ethics, Ch. 04)

Feeling-centered view

Pure logic alone cannot generate moral motivation — empathy and moral emotions (guilt, compassion, indignation) are what actually drive ethical behavior and are a legitimate SOURCE of moral knowledge, not just noise to filter out

Integrated view (most widely accepted today)

Sound moral judgment typically requires BOTH — reason to evaluate consistency and consequences, and feeling to recognize what's actually at stake for those affected

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Determinism vs Free Will — Why It Matters for Ethics

If human choices are entirely determined by prior causes (genetics, upbringing, brain chemistry, circumstance) with no genuine freedom involved, can anyone truly be held morally responsible for anything? This is a foundational question ethics must address before moral judgment can even begin.

Position	Core Claim
Hard Determinism	All events, including human choices, are fully caused by prior events — genuine free will is an illusion, which would undermine traditional moral responsibility entirely
Libertarian Free Will	Humans possess a genuine capacity for free, uncaused choice, at least in some situations — this preserves the

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Position

Core Claim

traditional basis
for moral
responsibility

Compatibilism

Free will and
determinism
can coexist —
"freedom" just
means acting
according to
one's own
reasons and
desires without
external
coercion, even if
those reasons/
desires
themselves
have prior
causes; the
most common
working
assumption for
practical ethics

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Filipino Cultural Concept — Kagandahang-Loob & Loob

Filipino moral philosophy often centers the concept of **loob** (inner self/will) — genuine moral acts spring from one's authentic inner disposition, not mere external compliance. *Kagandahang-loob* (roughly, "beauty of will/inner goodness") describes acting rightly not from fear of punishment or external reward, but from a genuinely good inner character — a Filipino philosophical parallel to Western debates about intention and moral motivation covered in this chapter.

CHAPTER 03

Utilitarianism

The first of four major ethical frameworks — and the single most exam-heavy topic in this course. Utilitarianism judges actions by their **OUTCOMES**: an act is right if it produces the

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

greatest good for the greatest number.

Core Principle

The **Principle of Utility** (or "Greatest Happiness Principle"): an action is morally right to the extent that it maximizes overall happiness/wellbeing and minimizes overall suffering, considering EVERYONE affected — not just the person acting.

Key Philosophers

Jeremy Bentham

1748–1832 ·
England

Founder of Utilitarianism

Proposed the "hedonic calculus" — a method to quantitatively measure pleasure/pain by intensity, duration, certainty, and other factors, to calculate which action produces the most net happiness.

John Stuart Mill

1806–1873 ·
England

Refined Utilitarianism

Argued not all pleasures are equal — distinguished "higher" pleasures (intellectual, moral) from "lower" ones (purely physical), famously stating it's "better to be a human dissatisfied than a pig satisfied."

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Act Utilitarianism vs Rule Utilitarianism

Type	Core Idea	Weakness
Act Utilitarianism	Evaluate EACH individual action by its own specific consequences — what maximizes utility in THIS particular situation	Can justify clearly unjust acts (e.g. framing an innocent person) if doing so happens to produce better aggregate consequences in a specific case
Rule Utilitarianism	Follow the RULE that, if generally followed, would produce the greatest utility overall — even if breaking it might produce better results in one specific instance	Can become inconsistent with pure Act Utilitarianism's own logic — if breaking a rule truly maximizes utility, why not break it?

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

- 00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

- 01 What Is Ethics?
- 02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

- 03 Utilitarianism
- 04 Deontology (Kant)
- 05 Virtue Ethics
- 06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

- 07 Making Moral Decisions
- 08 Applied Ethics

Worked Case Application

CLASSIC SCENARIO – THE TROLLEY PROBLEM

A runaway trolley is about to kill 5 people. You can pull a lever to divert it onto a side track, where it will kill only 1 person instead.

Utilitarian analysis: Pull the lever. Five lives saved outweighs one life lost — the action that produces the greatest good for the greatest number is clearly the one that minimizes total deaths. This is the textbook case used to introduce Utilitarian reasoning, precisely because most people's initial intuition (pull the lever) aligns with the Utilitarian calculation — making it a useful entry point before harder variations complicate the picture.

Major Criticisms of Utilitarianism

Criticism	Explanation
Justifies harming innocents	If sacrificing one innocent person genuinely maximized overall utility, strict Act

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Criticism

Explanation

Utilitarianism would require it — conflicting with strong moral intuitions about individual rights

Impossible to calculate precisely

Accurately predicting and quantifying all consequences, for everyone affected, is practically impossible in real time

Ignores justice and rights

A purely outcome-focused view can override individual rights whenever violating them produces a "better" aggregate outcome — this criticism directly motivates the Deontological framework in Chapter 04

Demands too much

Taken strictly, Utilitarianism could require constantly sacrificing personal interests whenever doing so marginally increases total global utility — an extremely demanding standard for everyday life

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Forward Link — Chapter 04

Utilitarianism's biggest weakness — that it can justify sacrificing an innocent individual for the greater good — is EXACTLY what Kant's Deontological ethics (next chapter) was built to reject.

Understanding this direct tension between the two frameworks is one of the most commonly tested comparative questions in the course.

CHAPTER 04

Deontology — Kantian Ethics

Where Utilitarianism judges actions by OUTCOMES, Deontology judges actions by DUTY — whether the act itself follows a correct moral rule, REGARDLESS of consequences. This is the framework most directly built to fix Utilitarianism's biggest flaw.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Key Philosopher

Immanuel

Kant

1724–1804 ·

Prussia

(Germany)

Founder of Deontological Ethics

Argued moral worth comes from acting out of DUTY according to universal rational principles — not from the consequences an act happens to produce, and not from personal inclination or emotion.

The Categorical

Imperative — Kant's Core Test

Kant proposed a rational test for determining whether an action is morally permissible, stated in several equivalent formulations. Two are most commonly taught:

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Formulation

The Test

Universal
Law

"Act only according to that maxim whereby you can, at the same time, will that it should become a universal law." In plain terms: could EVERYONE act this way, without the action becoming self-defeating or contradictory? If not, the act is impermissible.

Humanity
Formula

"Act so that you treat humanity, whether in your own person or in that of another, always as an end and never merely as a means." People must never be used PURELY as tools for someone else's purposes — they must be respected as rational beings with inherent worth.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

- 00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

- 01 What Is Ethics?
- 02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

- 03 Utilitarianism
- 04 Deontology (Kant)
- 05 Virtue Ethics
- 06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

- 07 Making Moral Decisions
- 08 Applied Ethics

Worked Case Application

CLASSIC SCENARIO – THE LYING PROMISE

You desperately need money and consider borrowing it, promising to repay, while secretly knowing you never will.

Kantian analysis: Apply the Universal Law test — "Can I will that EVERYONE make false promises whenever convenient?" No: if lying promises became universal, the entire institution of promise-making would collapse (no one would trust a promise at all), making the very act of "promising" self-defeating. Therefore, making a false promise fails the test and is morally impermissible — REGARDLESS of how much good the borrowed money might do. This is the textbook illustration of duty overriding consequences.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Utilitarianism vs
Deontology — Direct
Comparison

Aspect	Utilitarianism	Deontology (Kant)
What determines rightness	Consequences/ outcomes	The act itself, judged against duty/ rational principle
Trolley problem answer	Pull the lever — minimizes total deaths	Contested among Kantians, but strict duty-based reasoning resists treating a person as a mere means to save others, making the answer far less clear-cut
Flexibility	High — no act is absolutely forbidden if outcomes justify it	Low — certain acts (like lying, using people merely as tools) are wrong

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Aspect	Utilitarianism	Deontology (Kant)
--------	----------------	-------------------

		regardless of outcome
Main strength	Intuitive for policy/large-scale decisions affecting many people	Protects individual rights from being overridden "for the greater good"

Major Criticisms of Deontology

Criticism	Explanation
-----------	-------------

Can produce rigid, seemingly wrong outcomes	Kant himself controversially argued lying is ALWAYS wrong, even to a murderer asking where your friend is hiding — critics see this as prioritizing rule-consistency over obviously better outcomes
Conflicting duties	Real situations can present two genuine duties that conflict (e.g. duty to honesty vs duty to protect an innocent person) with no clear resolution

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Criticism

Explanation

mechanism within the framework itself

Abstract and hard to apply

Determining exactly how to phrase the "maxim" being universalized in a real situation is often genuinely ambiguous

Exam-Critical Fact — "Deontology" Means Duty-Based

The term comes from the Greek *deon* ("duty/obligation"). Remembering this root helps you correctly distinguish Deontology (rule/duty-focused, Kant) from Utilitarianism (outcome-focused, Bentham/Mill) instantly on any identification question.

CHAPTER 05

Virtue Ethics

The oldest of the three major frameworks, and fundamentally different in approach — Virtue Ethics doesn't ask "what should I

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

DO?" primarily, but "what kind of PERSON should I BE?" Good actions flow naturally from good character.

Key Philosopher

Aristotle

384–322 BC ·
Ancient Greece

Founder of Virtue Ethics

Argued the goal of human life is *eudaimonia* (flourishing/ genuine wellbeing), achieved by cultivating virtuous character traits through habituated practice, not by following rules or calculating outcomes.

Eudaimonia — The Ultimate Goal

Eudaimonia is often translated as "happiness," but this is misleading — it means something closer to human FLOURISHING or living well, achieved through a lifetime of virtuous activity, not a fleeting

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

emotional state. For Aristotle, eudaimonia is the ultimate end that all human action aims toward.

The Doctrine of the Golden Mean

Aristotle argued each virtue is a MEAN (middle point) between two vices — one of excess, one of deficiency. Virtue is not about extremes in either direction, but about finding the appropriate balance for a given situation.

Vice of Deficiency	Virtue (The Mean)	Vice of Excess
Cowardice	Courage	Recklessness
Stinginess	Generosity	Wastefulness
Shamelessness	Modesty	Shyness/ Bashfulness
Apathy	Patience/ Good Temper	Irritability
Self-deprecation	Proper Pride	Vanity

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Exam-Critical Clarification — The Mean Is Not Simply "The Middle"

The Golden Mean is NOT a fixed mathematical midpoint — it's relative to the situation and the individual. What counts as "courage" varies depending on context (a soldier's courage looks different from a whistleblower's courage). This is a frequently tested nuance that separates a strong answer from a superficial one.

Virtue as Habit — Not Innate, Not Just Knowledge

Aristotle insisted virtues are develop through HABITUATED PRACTICE, not simply granted at birth or acquired purely through intellectual understanding. You become courageous by repeatedly performing courageous acts until courage becomes part of your character — similar to how you become a skilled musician through repeated practice, not just by reading music theory.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Worked Case
Application

CLASSIC SCENARIO – THE
TROLLEY PROBLEM, VIRTUE LENS

Applying Virtue Ethics to
the same trolley scenario
from Chapter 03.

Virtue Ethics analysis: Unlike Utilitarianism or Deontology, Virtue Ethics doesn't offer a single calculable "correct" answer — instead it asks: what would a genuinely PRACTICALLY WISE person (someone with *phronesis*, practical wisdom) do in this exact situation, considering courage, justice, and compassion together? This is often criticized as less decisive than the other two frameworks, but Virtue Ethicists argue real moral situations rarely reduce to a single clean rule anyway — character and judgment matter more than a formula.

Three Frameworks —
Side-by-Side
Summary

Framework	Central Question	Key Thinker
Utilitarianism	"What action	Bentham, Mill

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Framework

Central
Question

Key
Thinker

produces
the best
outcome
for
everyone
affected?"

Deontology

"What
does duty/
universal
rational
principle
require,
regardless
of
outcome?"

Kant

Virtue Ethics

"What
would a
genuinely
virtuous
person do,
and how
do I
become
that kind
of
person?"

Aristotle

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Filipino Connection — Pakikipagkapwa & Virtue

Filipino virtue concepts like *pakikisama* (getting along/ camaraderie) and *utang na loob* (debt of gratitude/ reciprocity) function similarly to Aristotelian virtues — they're character traits cultivated through lived social practice, not abstract rules, and are judged by contextual wisdom (*pakiramdam*, sensitivity to a situation) rather than rigid calculation.

CHAPTER 06

Natural Law & Justice/Rights

Two more frameworks that frequently appear alongside the "big three" — Natural Law grounds morality in human nature itself, while theories of Justice and Rights focus on fair distribution and inviolable entitlements.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026–2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Natural Law Theory

Thomas

Aquinas

1225–1274 ·

Italy

**Leading
Natural Law
Theorist**

Argued morality is grounded in human NATURE itself — humans have inherent purposes (rationality, sociability, self-preservation), and moral acts are those that align with fulfilling these natural human ends.

Natural Law holds that certain moral truths can be discovered through REASON by examining human nature — they exist independently of any human-made law or convention, similar in spirit to Ethical Universalism (Ch. 01) but grounded specifically in what humans are naturally FOR.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Key Principle	Explanation
---------------	-------------

Basic goods	Life, knowledge, sociability, reasonableness — things naturally good for any human being to pursue
-------------	--

"Do good, avoid evil"	The foundational precept from which more specific moral rules are derived through reasoning about human nature
-----------------------	--

Human/civil law must align with natural law	An unjust human law (one that violates natural law) is, in a meaningful sense, not genuinely binding — directly echoes the Rizal Law civil-disobedience discussion from your RIZAL course
---	---

Theories of Justice

John Rawls

1921–2002 · USA

"A Theory of Justice" (1971)

Proposed the "veil of ignorance" thought experiment: imagine designing society's rules

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

- 00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

- 01 What Is Ethics?
- 02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

- 03 Utilitarianism
- 04 Deontology (Kant)
- 05 Virtue Ethics
- 06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

- 07 Making Moral Decisions
- 08 Applied Ethics

WITHOUT knowing your own future position in it (rich/poor, majority/minority) — you'd rationally choose rules that are fair even to society's worst-off members, since you might BE that person.

Rawls's Two Principles of Justice

Principle	Content
1. Equal Basic Liberties	Every person has an equal claim to the same basic rights and freedoms (speech, conscience, political participation)
2. Difference Principle	Social/economic inequalities are only justified if they work to the benefit of society's LEAST advantaged members

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Human Rights Theory

Human rights are moral entitlements held simply by virtue of being human — not granted by government, and (in principle) not revocable by government either. This framework underlies most modern international law, including the UN framework you studied in SOCSCI 3.

Characteristic	Meaning
Universal	Apply to all humans, regardless of nationality, culture, or government recognition
Inalienable	Cannot be legitimately taken away or voluntarily given up, even by the person themselves
Indivisible	Civil/political rights (speech, voting) and economic/social rights (education, healthcare) are considered equally

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Characteristic

Meaning

fundamental,
not a hierarchy

Connects to SOCSCI 3

Human rights theory here is the philosophical FOUNDATION for the UN human rights framework and international law concepts you covered in SOCSCI 3's Global Governance chapter — that course explained the institutions; this chapter explains the philosophical justification behind why those institutions claim authority at all.

Four Frameworks — Full Comparison

Framework

Grounds
Morality In

Utilitarianism

Consequences — maximizing overall wellbeing

Deontology

Duty — universal rational principles (Categorical Imperative)

Virtue Ethics

Character — what a genuinely virtuous person would do

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Framework**Grounds
Morality In**

Natural Law

Human nature —
acts aligned with
our natural
purposes

CHAPTER 07

Making Moral Decisions

Knowing the four frameworks isn't enough — this chapter gives you a structured PROCESS for actually working through a real moral dilemma, which is exactly the skill most exams and case-study assignments are testing.

A Structured Moral Decision-Making Process

1

Identify the moral issue

What exactly is the ethical question at stake? Separate the moral issue from any legal, practical, or emotional side-issues clouding it.

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

2

Gather the relevant facts

Who is affected? What are the realistic options? What do we actually know versus assume? Many "dilemmas" partly dissolve once the facts are fully clear.

3

Identify the stakeholders

List everyone whose interests, rights, or wellbeing are affected by each possible choice — including people not directly present in the situation.

4

Apply multiple ethical frameworks

Work through the situation using Utilitarian, Deontological, and Virtue lenses (Ch. 03-05) separately. Where do they agree? Where do they conflict, and why?

5

Consider alternative courses of action

Is the dilemma truly binary, or are there creative third options that better satisfy multiple frameworks at once?

6

Make a reasoned decision

Choose a course of action and be able to articulate WHY — which framework(s) most strongly justify it, and honestly acknowledge what's being sacrificed by not choosing the alternatives.

7

Reflect on the outcome

After acting (or in a case study, after analyzing), evaluate whether the reasoning holds up — would you decide the same way in a similar future situation?

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

- 00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

- 01 What Is Ethics?
- 02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

- 03 Utilitarianism
- 04 Deontology (Kant)
- 05 Virtue Ethics
- 06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

- 07 Making Moral Decisions
- 08 Applied Ethics

Exam-Critical Skill — Multi-Framework Analysis

The strongest case-study answers don't just pick ONE framework and stop — they explicitly show how Utilitarian, Deontological, and Virtue perspectives EACH analyze the same scenario, then explain which framework's reasoning is most convincing for that specific case and why. This demonstrates you understand the frameworks as genuinely different tools, not interchangeable synonyms.

Worked Full Example

FULL CASE APPLICATION

A pharmacist has a life-saving medicine a poor family desperately needs but cannot afford. Should the pharmacist give it away for free, against store policy?

Utilitarian view: If the family's life saved clearly outweighs the pharmacist's financial loss and any precedent-setting harm, giving the medicine away maximizes overall utility.

Deontological view: Depends on which duty is emphasized —

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

a duty to preserve life could justify giving the medicine away; a duty to honor contractual/professional obligations to the store could argue against it. Kant would likely stress the universalizability question: could everyone systematically break store policy whenever they judged it sympathetically justified?

Virtue Ethics view: Asks what a compassionate, practically wise pharmacist would do — likely weighing generosity and justice together, perhaps seeking a middle path (partial discount, connecting the family to assistance programs) rather than a stark either/or choice.

This is exactly the kind of multi-angle answer that scores well on case-study exams.

CHAPTER 08

Applied Ethics

This closing chapter applies the four frameworks (Ch. 03-06) to specific real-world domains — the kind of concrete, current topics

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

most likely to appear in your final position paper or reflection essay.

Bioethics

Issue	Core Ethical Tension
End-of-life care / euthanasia	Autonomy and mercy (reducing suffering) versus the sanctity of life and risk of abuse/ coercion of vulnerable patients
Abortion	Bodily autonomy of the pregnant person versus the moral status and rights of the fetus — a genuinely contested question across all four frameworks
Genetic engineering	Potential to prevent disease and suffering versus risks of inequality (only the wealthy accessing enhancement) and "playing god" concerns rooted in Natural Law thinking

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Environmental Ethics

Does nature have moral value only because of its USE to humans (anthropocentrism), or does the environment itself hold intrinsic moral worth regardless of human benefit (ecocentrism)? This directly connects to the climate justice discussion from your SOCSCI 3 course — the Philippines' extreme climate vulnerability despite minimal historical emissions is a frequently cited applied ethics case study combining Utilitarian (aggregate harm), Rights-based (a right to a livable environment), and Justice (who bears responsibility for fixing a problem they didn't primarily cause) reasoning simultaneously.

Technology & AI Ethics

Issue	Core Ethical Tension
AI decision-making	Efficiency and consistency (Utilitarian appeal) versus accountability and transparency when an algorithm, not a

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Issue

Core Ethical
Tension

person, makes a consequential decision

Data privacy

Convenience and innovation versus an individual's right to control their own personal information (Rights-based framing)

Automation and job displacement

Overall economic efficiency (Utilitarian) versus fairness to displaced workers who bear concentrated costs for society's diffuse benefit (Justice-based framing, echoing Rawls's difference principle from Ch. 06)

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Direct Connection to
Your BSIT Degree

As a future IT professional, this section isn't abstract — it previews **SPI 101** (Social and Professional Issues, Year 3 Summer), a full course dedicated to professional and technology ethics specifically for IT practitioners. The frameworks you're learning right now (Ch. 03-06) are the actual toolkit used to reason through real dilemmas like "should I flag a security vulnerability that might get a colleague fired?" or "is it ethical to build a system I know could be misused?"

Business Ethics

Issue	Core Ethical Tension
Fair wages vs profit maximization	Shareholder interests (often framed in Utilitarian terms — efficient markets benefit society overall) versus worker dignity and fair compensation

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

Issue

Core Ethical
Tension

(Rights/Justice framing)

Whistleblowing

Loyalty to employer/colleagues versus duty to prevent harm to the public — a genuine conflict-of-duties case, similar to the Deontological tension discussed in Ch. 04

Advertising to vulnerable groups

Free market persuasion versus exploiting cognitive biases or vulnerabilities (e.g. children, financially desperate people)

Filipino Moral Values
in Applied Context

Filipino ethics often blends Western frameworks with distinctly local values: **Bayanihan** (communal unity/mutual aid) reflects Virtue Ethics'

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

emphasis on cultivated generosity as character; **Hiya** (a sense of shame/social propriety) functions as an internalized moral regulator similar to Kantian duty, but is socially rather than purely rationally derived; **Utang na loob** (debt of gratitude) creates ongoing relational obligations that don't map neatly onto any single Western framework, illustrating that lived Filipino ethics is genuinely a **SYNTHESIS**, not a simple import of Western theory.

Closing Synthesis — The Question This Course Builds Toward

Nearly every final position paper in this course asks you to take a real, contested applied ethics issue and defend a position using **MULTIPLE** frameworks explicitly, while acknowledging the strongest objections to your own view. The strongest papers don't declare one framework "correct" and dismiss the others — they show genuine command of all four, using each to stress-test the others' conclusions.

HUM 2 · QCU BSIT

Ethics

Complete Study Guide · AY 2026-2027

INTRODUCTION

00 Course Overview

FOUNDATIONS

01 What Is Ethics?

02 The Moral Agent

ETHICAL FRAMEWORKS

03 Utilitarianism

04 Deontology (Kant)

05 Virtue Ethics

06 Natural Law & Justice

APPLICATION

07 Making Moral Decisions

08 Applied Ethics

HUM 2 — Ethics · Complete Study Guide

QCU Academic OS · Compiled by

KianoRoku18Ino · [github.com/](https://github.com/KianoRoku18Ino)

KianoRoku18Ino · AY 2026-2027

QCU Academic OS v4.1 · Semester Zero

Advance Prep Material